

WHY

DO PEOPLE GO TO WAR?

People have conflicting needs and wants, and war is one of the options used to resolve their disputes. When one group wants power or control over another or wants to keep or gain control of a valuable resource, war may be a means to an end. But there are many other reasons for war, including the quest for glory, religious intolerance, and even ethnic cleansing.

HOW

LONG HAVE PEOPLE BEEN FIGHTING WARS?

Throughout history, people have fought one another, from quick raids on a neighboring village to epic battles. In some societies, war was infrequent, while other groups fought almost constantly. One example is the city of Sparta in ancient Greece, whose entire society revolved around brutal warfare. Historians say that despite the superiority of modern weapons, the people who fought battles in ancient times had a much greater chance of dying at the hands of another person than we do today.

CAN

WAR EVER BE JUSTIFIED?

In the past, many societies saw war as a noble and good thing. Warriors were considered heroes. Today, more and more people question the morality of going to war. In modern times, wars are deemed "just" when they stop a dangerous person, nation, or group. There are only two justifications for going to war under international law—defending a country after an attack from another party or under agreement of the United Nations (UN) against a particular country, if they fail to meet the imposed sanctions.

